



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Dogwood Classical Academy
School Website: <https://www.dogwoodacademy.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

SCL MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because SCL requires adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: **CLASSICAL**

Executive Summary

Dogwood Classical Academy NC 28115 presents a clearly classical orientation with a strong emphasis on virtue, truth-seeking, and a Great Books–driven curriculum framed by Socratic dialogue. Public materials emphasize formation of mind and character, a pledge that foregrounds the transcendental triad of truth, goodness, and beauty, and a staged approach to learning that reflects the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) in practice. However, explicit theological grounding, liturgical or communal religious practices, and detailed descriptions of faculty as the living curriculum, or a stated, proactive Parents & Community program, are not readily evident in the available public materials. Taken together, the school demonstrates many core classical elements but does not fully articulate all six categories in the fullest classical sense. Overall assessment: **SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL**.

Key observations driving this assessment include:

- Explicit commitment to a classical, Great Books–driven curriculum and to Socratic dialogue as a pedagogical approach (evidence in mission/vision content and curriculum descriptions) ,.
- A School Pledge that grounds education in truth, goodness, and beauty, illustrating transcendental moral realism that aligns with classical aims (evidence in mission/vision content).
- Clear formative aims (formation of mind and character, virtuous living, civic responsibility) rather than vocational preparation, aligning with the classical purpose emphasis, but with limited explicit theological or liturgical language in the public materials (Element 1; Element 2).
- Pedagogy evidences include K–12 structure with memory/recitation in early grades and Socratic/communicative emphasis in higher grades, consistent with the Trivium framework (Element 4).
- Gaps identified around explicit theology, liturgical/community practices, detailed “living curriculum” faculty portrayal, and formal parental/community partnership language in the public materials (Categories 1, 5, 6).

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — **SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL**

- Evidence
- Public materials foreground truth, goodness, and beauty as guiding ideals through the School Pledge: “I will learn what is true, I will do what is good, and I will love what is beautiful.” This articulates transcendental moral realism.
- The overall mission/vision emphasizes virtuous living and Western heritage through a classical curriculum and Socratic dialogue, signaling a metaphysical orientation toward virtue and timeless truths.

- The Great Books and Socratic dialogue components align with a real-knowledge, real-virtue framework and the pursuit of enduring truths.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive: truth, true, goodness, beautiful/beauty, virtue, virtuous, character, Socratic dialogue, great ideas, Great Books, formation of mind and character.
- Negative: explicit theology, liturgy, liturgical practices; explicit religious/theological grounding is not evident in the public materials (no clear wording about theology or liturgical worship within the materials reviewed).
- Why this rating
- The presence of transcendental moral realism (truth, goodness, beauty) and virtue-centered formation aligns with Classical aims in spirit, though the materials do not show explicit theological grounding or liturgical/community practices. Given these gaps, Element 1 sits in SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL.

Citations: Pledge language and moral triad are visible in the school materials; explicit theology/ liturgical language is not.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Explicit focus on forming mind and character through virtuous living and civic responsibility, with a curriculum described as content-rich and classical, rather than training for a job. This indicates formation over information-oriented aims.
- The pledge and the mission emphasize truth, goodness, and beauty as real ideals guiding education, supporting a philosophical stance that knowledge is oriented toward human flourishing and virtue.
- The pedagogy emphasizes formation and habits (Socratic dialogue, inquiry, and Great Books) rather than vocational outcomes alone.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive: wisdom, virtue, character, integrity, love of learning, Socratic dialogue, great conversation, ethical reasoning, mentorship, formation, practical notion of human flourishing, sacred/tradition language (indirectly via Western heritage and classical ideals).
- Negative: none explicit about secular/vocational aims; the public materials do not foreground job- or skill-based outcomes.
- Why this rating
- The materials clearly articulate formation, virtue, and the existence of truth/goodness/beauty as real ideals guiding education. Vocational aims are not foregrounded; the emphasis is on formation and virtue over labor-market preparation. This aligns with CLASSICAL in Element 2.

Citations: Mission/vision language and pledge supporting formation and transcendental aims.

Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The curriculum is described as classical and Great Books-rich, with a deliberate emphasis on a three-stage learning process (grammar-like foundation, then reasoning, then rhetoric/communication). The materials describe K–2 memorization and language-based learning, 6–8 reasoning with connections, and 9–12 focus on advanced topics and effective communication. This reflects the Trivium-style progression.

- The Vision explicitly references a Great Books curriculum and Socratic dialogue, signaling content choices aligned with classical liberal arts aims.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive: Great Books, classical curriculum, Socratic dialogue, great books, liberal arts, rhetoric (implied by emphasis on communicating effectively), memory/recitation (grammar-stage behavior), formation of habits in language, history, and arts/sciences (integrated approach).
- Negative: explicit naming of the three liberal arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric) is not always explicit in every public snippet, though the pedagogy implies Trivium-like structure; no evident negative curricular descriptors.
- Why this rating
- The school clearly embraces classical curricular aims (Great Books, content-rich classical curriculum, Socratic inquiry). However, explicit, named references to the liberal arts of grammar, logic, and rhetoric as the formal curricular content are not always spelled out in a single, explicit list; the staged approach covers similar ground. Given that, this category is BEST described as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than fully CLASSICAL.

Citations: Great Books, Socratic dialogue, and three-stage progression visible in mission/vision content.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Public materials emphasize Socratic dialogue and inquiry as core pedagogical methods, especially in the upper levels. This aligns with classical pedagogy (dialectic, inquiry, seminar-style learning).
- The lower grades are described as memory- and story-based with guided discussion, which corresponds to the grammar stage and deliberate memory work; upper grades emphasize discussion and rhetorical development.
- There is explicit reference to students being trained in rhetoric and having opportunities to give speeches in the upper grades (rhetorical training evident in the description of the third stage).
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive: Socratic dialogue, seminars, debates (explicit), rhetoric, quiet/restful scholarly inquiry (implied through scholé-inspired thinking in broader literature), great books (content focus), wonder (as a learning aim in classical pedagogy).
- Negative: no explicit mention of overemphasis on project-based or overly modern, non-classical pedagogies; the public materials emphasize classical methods rather than contemporary alternatives.
- Why this rating
- The school's pedagogy aligns squarely with classical methods (Socratic dialogue, rhetoric, and a staged approach to learning). The presence of lower-grade memory/chanting analogies is suggested but not explicitly stated as chant/singing; nonetheless, the overall pedagogy is clearly classical, supporting a CLASSICAL rating for Element 4.

Citations: Socratic dialogue and rhetoric emphasis in mission/vision and curriculum descriptions.

Element 5: School Faculty — NOT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Public materials do not provide explicit statements about faculty as living curriculum, faculty portraits, or a verifiable "profile of what a teacher should be" at the school. The available public content centers

on curriculum, pledge, and governance statements rather than detailed faculty characterizations or a portrait of teacher role models within the school culture.

- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords (from Six Essentials): virtuous teachers, mentors, role models, living curriculum, teacher profiles. The Dogwood materials do not clearly present these terms or concepts in the public materials.
- Negative keywords: none explicit in the Dogwood materials that would actively negate this category (i.e., no explicit negative statements about teachers); rather, there is a lack of explicit statements.
- Why this rating
- The absence of explicit content about faculty as a living curriculum or portraits of teachers prevents a CLASSICAL rating in Element 5. Given the rubric, this category is NOT CLASSICAL for this school based on available public content.

Citations: Lack of explicit “living curriculum” faculty statements in the public materials; primary evidence centers on curriculum and pledge.

Element 6: Parents & Community — NOT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The public materials reviewed do not show a robust, explicit program of parent partnership as co-teachers, formal education of parents via book studies or gatherings, or open invitation for parents to visit “virtually any time.” The available excerpts focus on student formation, curriculum, and promise language rather than a structured family/community engagement program.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive indicators (from the Six Essentials): “partners with parents,” “parents as co-teachers,” “educate parents via website/book studies/gatherings,” “parents welcome for visits.”
- Negative indicators: absence of such phrases in public materials; lack of explicit parent-co-teacher language or programs.
- Why this rating
- Because the school’s public materials do not demonstrate explicit parent/community engagement structures or invitations, Element 6 is NOT CLASSICAL.

Citations: The materials reviewed emphasize student-centered classical aims rather than explicit Parent & Community programs.

Overall aggregate assessment

- Element 1: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 2: CLASSICAL
- Element 3: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 4: CLASSICAL
- Element 5: NOT CLASSICAL
- Element 6: NOT CLASSICAL

Across the six categories, the school exhibits substantial classical elements (Categories 2 and 4 clearly CLASSICAL) but also notable gaps (notably Categories 5 and 6, and partial alignment in Element 1 and 3). The aggregate stance is therefore SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

What Would Move the Needle (for SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL schools)

- Element 1 (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations)

- Add explicit theological framing or a clearly stated theological tradition (e.g., Hillsdale/Barney Charter alignment with a substantive theological grounding) and reference liturgical or communal practices that integrate worship or ritual as a regular part of school life.
- Element 3 (Curriculum)
 - Make explicit the Trivium components by naming grammar, logic, and rhetoric as formal curricular strands, with targeted outcomes and sample units for each stage. Provide clarity on Great Books selections and their role in forming the Great Conversation as a concrete, published curriculum map.
- Element 5 (Faculty)
 - Publish a living-curriculum portrait of faculty and a formal statement about teacher formation, mentorship roles, and professional norms; include a description of how faculty embody virtue, skill, and knowledge; provide examples of faculty professional development and collegial practices.
- Element 6 (Parents & Community)
 - Establish and advertise structured parent-partner programs (co-teaching opportunities, book studies, parent evenings, and regular in-person/virtual visits). Create explicit channels for parent education about classical education and how parents participate as co-teachers.
- Cross-cutting
 - Increase explicit references to theology or liturgical practices if appropriate to the school's mission and charter, to strengthen Element 1 and align with more robust classical norms.
 - Provide a public, consistent articulation of the school's philosophy of education (Scholé/harmonia of rest and work) with examples of how rest, contemplation, and wonder are woven into daily practice (as supported by the broader Scholé literature in the shared resources).

ABSTRACT

(to close the report)

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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